SACRED SEASONS · ADVENT 2026

Week 3: Joy Through Tears

December 13 to 19 · Spiritual practices for small groups and personal prayer

This week's prayer

God, let me receive joy as your gift without forcing it, and let me know who I am before I know what I do.

HOW TO USE THESE PRACTICES

- This week has four passages for Lectio Divina (pray one each day, or choose one for a gathering) and two practices to lead with a small group or pray on your own. Each takes 10 to 20 minutes.
- If you are leading a group, read the steps aloud slowly. Let the silences be long enough to feel a little long.
- Offer the questions as invitations. No one has to answer out loud, and there are no wrong answers.
- Every practice is also in the free Sacred Seasons app, where you can read it or listen as Dr. Julene guides you: sacredseasons.julenetegerstrand.com

BEFORE YOU LEAD

You can't manufacture joy for your people. Where have you felt joy lately without trying? What are you sowing in tears?

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PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

Psalm 126:3-6

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether you have people share their words and thoughts out loud or if they do this in silence. If you do each round in silence, give people time to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

Psalm 126 remembers a time when God restored everything, and the people felt like they were dreaming. Then it asks God to do it again, because things are dry right now. The watercourses of the Negeb are desert streambeds that fill suddenly when the rain comes.

> 3 *The Lord has done great things for us,*
> *and we rejoiced.*
> 4 *Restore our fortunes, O Lord,*
> *like the watercourses in the Negeb.*
> 5 *May those who sow in tears*
> *reap with shouts of joy.*
> 6 *Those who go out weeping,*
> *bearing the seed for sowing,*
> *shall come home with shouts of joy,*
> *carrying their sheaves.*
>
> Psalm 126:3-6 (NRSVue)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. You don't need to know why it catches you. Just notice it.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. What in your life feels like dry ground right now? What are you sowing in tears? Where do you hope for the rain? *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again, and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God? You can ask for restoration. You can tell God about your tears. You can thank God for a harvest you've already seen.

Fourth reading. Now rest. You don't have to force yourself to be joyful. Just rest, and let joy come when it comes.

Carry with you: *"Those who go out weeping… shall come home with shouts of joy."*

Try this: Today, notice one small good moment, and say quietly, "The Lord has done great things."

PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

Isaiah 61:1-3

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether you have people share their words and thoughts out loud or do this in silence. If you do each round in silence, give people time to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

This is part of the passage Jesus read aloud in the synagogue at Nazareth. It describes God's care for grieving people as an exchange. In the ancient world, mourners put ashes on their heads. At a wedding, people wore a garland.

> 1 *The spirit of the Lord God is upon me*
> *because the Lord has anointed me;*
> *he has sent me to bring good news to the oppressed,*
> *to bind up the brokenhearted,*
> *to proclaim liberty to the captives*
> *and release to the prisoners,*
> 2 *to proclaim the year of the Lord's favor*
> *and the day of vengeance of our God,*
> *to comfort all who mourn,*
> 3 *to provide for those who mourn in Zion—*
> *to give them a garland instead of ashes,*
> *the oil of gladness instead of mourning,*
> *the mantle of praise instead of a faint spirit.*
> *They will be called oaks of righteousness,*
> *the planting of the Lord, to display his glory.*
>
> Isaiah 61:1-3 (NRSVue)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. You don't need to know why it catches you. Just notice it.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. What grief are you carrying this Advent? What might God want to give you to hold beside it? *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again, and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God? You can name your grief. You can ask for gladness to come. You can pray for someone else who mourns.

Fourth reading. Now rest. Your grief and God's gift can sit side by side. God holds both.

Carry with you: *"A garland instead of ashes."*

Try this: Today, bring one small piece of good news to someone who is grieving: a visit, a meal, a note.

PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

1 Thessalonians 5:16-19

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether people share their words and thoughts aloud or do this in silence. If you do each round in silence, give people time to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

Paul ends his letter to a young church with short, bright instructions. He isn't asking them to be happy about everything. He's asking them to keep turning toward God in everything.

> 16 *Rejoice always, 17 pray without ceasing, 18 give thanks in all circumstances, for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you. 19 Do not quench the Spirit.*
>
> 1 Thessalonians 5:16-19 (NRSVue)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. You don't need to know why it catches you. Just notice it.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. Which of these feels closest to you right now: rejoice, pray, give thanks? Which feels hardest? *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again, and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God? You might give thanks for one thing. You might tell God honestly where it's hard to rejoice.

Fourth reading. Now rest. Joy is a gift, not a task. Let prayer be as plain as breathing.

Carry with you: *"Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances."*

Try this: Three times today, notice one small good moment, pause for ten seconds, and say, "Thank you."

PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

John 1:6-8

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether you have people share their words and thoughts out loud or if they do this in silence. If you do each round in silence, give people time to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

John's Gospel introduces John the Baptist carefully. God sent him, and he is a witness. The Gospel also says plainly what he is not.

> 6 *There was a man sent from God whose name was John. 7 He came as a witness to testify to the light, so that all might believe through him. 8 He himself was not the light, but he came to testify to the light.*
>
> John 1:6-8 (NRSVue)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. You don't need to know why it catches you. Just notice it.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. Where have you seen the light lately? What would it free you from knowing that you are not the light yourself? *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again, and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God? You might thank God for the light you've seen. You might set down something you've been carrying that was never yours to carry.

Fourth reading. Now rest. You are not the light. Your part is to notice it, and point to it.

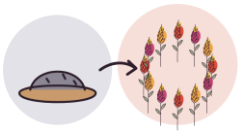
Carry with you: *"He himself was not the light, but he came to testify to the light."*

Try this: Today, tell one person about a place where you have seen light.

A PRACTICE FOR A SMALL GROUP

Ashes and Garland

Group or household · 15 minutes



Isaiah 61 is the passage Jesus read aloud in the synagogue at Nazareth. It describes God's care for grieving people as an exchange: "a garland instead of ashes, the oil of gladness instead of mourning, the mantle of praise instead of a faint spirit." In the ancient world, and in many cultures still, mourners put ashes or dust on

In this practice, nobody is asked to let go of their grief. You receive something to hold beside it. Grief and gratitude are sisters in the emotional landscape of our lives. It is okay to let them be together.

> 1 *The spirit of the Lord God is upon me*
> *because the Lord has anointed me;*
> *he has sent me to bring good news to the oppressed,*
> *to bind up the brokenhearted,*
> *to proclaim liberty to the captives*
> *and release to the prisoners,*
> 2 *to proclaim the year of the Lord's favor*
> *and the day of vengeance of our God,*
> *to comfort all who mourn,*
> 3 *to provide for those who mourn in Zion—*
> *to give them a garland instead of ashes,*
> *the oil of gladness instead of mourning,*
> *the mantle of praise instead of a faint spirit.*
> *They will be called oaks of righteousness,*
> *the planting of the Lord, to display his glory.*
>
> Isaiah 61:1-3 (NRSVue)

YOU'LL NEED

A bowl of sand or ashes, small slips of paper, pens, and sprigs of evergreen, short lengths of ribbon or paper, or real flowers.

STEPS

1. Read verses 1 through 3 aloud, slowly.
2. Write one grief on a slip of paper. You can write it in any language, or use a single word or symbol. No one else will read it.
3. Fold it and place it in the bowl.
4. Keep a minute of silence.
5. Receive a sprig of evergreen (or whatever was chosen) from someone (or pick one up yourself) while hearing the words, "a garland instead of ashes."

6. Hold the sprig for a while. Take it home and put it where you'll see it.

QUESTIONS TO PRAY WITH OR SHARE

- What was it like to put my grief down in the bowl, even for a moment?
- What was it like to receive something while still carrying sorrow?
- Whose grief am I carrying besides my own?
- What might gladness look like for me this year, if it came in small ways?

IF YOU'RE TIRED

Write a single word on the slip.

WITH A GROUP, HOUSEHOLD, OR CHILDREN

Leaders: keep the slips private. Afterward, bury or burn them respectfully, or let people take theirs home if they'd rather.

> **A word of care.** This practice can bring up tears. Offer a calm space nearby, and let people take part by watching. Grief looks different across cultures and families. Some people cry loudly, some are silent, some laugh. All of it is welcome. If it feels better not to 'give up the grief' invite people to keep it and take the sprig too. Another option is to give them two pieces of paper: one grief to put in the bowl as a way of saying, God, can you hold me in my grief, and then one grief (the same words) they take with them.

A PRACTICE FOR A SMALL GROUP

The Magnificat from the Margins

Personal or group · 20 minutes



Mary was a young Jewish woman from a poor village in an occupied land. Her song is joy with an edge. The powerful come down from their thrones, those who are lowly are lifted up, and those who have hunger are filled with good things.

Communities that have carried long grief and injustice have sung this song with deep memory, and their joy includes that memory. This practice prays Mary's song alongside someone whose life is hard.

> 46 *"My soul magnifies the Lord,*
> 47 *and my spirit rejoices in God my Savior,*
> 48 *for he has looked with favor on the lowly state of his servant.*
> *Surely from now on all generations will call me blessed,*
> 49 *for the Mighty One has done great things for me,*
> *and holy is his name;*
> 50 *indeed, his mercy is for those who fear him*
> *from generation to generation.*
> 51 *He has shown strength with his arm;*
> *he has scattered the proud in the imagination of their hearts.*
> 52 *He has brought down the powerful from their thrones*
> *and lifted up the lowly;*
> 53 *he has filled the hungry with good things*
> *and sent the rich away empty.*
> 54 *He has come to the aid of his child Israel,*
> *in remembrance of his mercy,*
> 55 *according to the promise he made to our ancestors,*
> *to Abraham and to his descendants forever."*
>
> Luke 1:46b-55 (NRSVue)

STEPS

1. Today, spend time listening to one person whose life is hard. It could be a neighbor, a coworker, or a patient. It could also be a news story you read slowly and with care.
2. Listen fully, with curiosity. Resist the urge to fix, advise, or explain.
3. Afterward, pray the Magnificat slowly on that person's behalf. At the lines about the lowly and the hungry, hold them in mind.

4. Notice what stirs in you: anger, grief, hope, discomfort. Tell God. Anger at injustice can be holy.
5. Ask whether there's one small thing you could do alongside them.

QUESTIONS TO PRAY WITH OR SHARE

- Where do I stand in Mary's song: among the lowly, the powerful, the hungry, the full? Maybe in more than one place?
- What did I learn from listening that I couldn't have learned any other way?
- What in me resists the song's reversals, and what in me longs for them?
- What might it mean to sing this song together with the people it describes?

IF YOU'RE TIRED

Pray only verse 52 or 53, for one person.

WITH A GROUP, HOUSEHOLD, OR CHILDREN

A group can read the Magnificat aloud in two halves, adding the names of places in your town where people are waiting to be lifted up. Invite anyone who knows the song in another language to pray it that way.

> **A word of care.** People's pain is never material for our prayers or sermons. Keep confidences, and don't retell anyone's story without their permission. If you're living on the margins right now, this song was written from where you are standing.

Sacred Seasons

A free Advent prayer app from spiritual director Rev. Dr. Julene Tegerstrand. One prayer each day from November 29 to Christmas Eve, to read or to hear. No ads, no account. You can sign up or find out more at sacredseasons.julenetegerstrand.com

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